How far was the directors' report reflective of the real status of the company?

The Tirunelveli DSP provided an elaborate critique of this report.[77] Questioning the company's claim that it could earn a monthly gross profit of Rs 10,000 if the services could be revived, he further described the projected position of the company on 31 December 1912, i.e. three years down the line (paid-up capital Rs 15 lakh; cash on hand, Rs 3,78,500; debt, nil; depreciation fund with interest, Rs 63,500; reserve fund, Rs 36,500), as 'hugely sanguine'. He also wondered how the company assumed that the competition would cease after December 1910. He then shared news about the company's debts meant to further please his superiors: the *Lawoe* was heavily mortgaged and would be sold in Colombo soon. Decrees for Rs 22,400 plus 2,720, plus 3,503 totalling Rs 28,623 had already been obtained. The Bombay High Court too had issued a decree for an unpaid Rs 10,000 for the *Lawoe*'s repairs.[78] If this was the police officer's analysis, details from a nationalist newspaper, *Amrita Bazar Patrika*, were no less discomforting. Messrs Charles Brown, in April 1909, had executed extensive repairs to the *Lawoe*, and raised a bill of Rs 37,462. SSNCo had made two payments—of Rs 6,000 and Rs 19,000—leaving a balance of Rs 10,462, which sum the company declined to settle alleging that the charges were exorbitant and that some of the work charged had not actually been executed. The dispute went for arbitration, and Charles Brown was awarded Rs 9,915, apart from Rs 1,194 as interest and costs. SSNCo appealed against the arbitration award and got it set aside. Finally, the Bombay High Court, 'after hearing the evidence in the case and the agreements of counsel passed a decree for the amount claimed apart from the arbitration fee, and half of the interest amount claimed and the cost of the suit'.[79]

The final assessment of the Swadeshi-friendly *Amrita Bazar Patrika* was damning: 'The publication of the report had caused keen and widespread disappointment amongst the public and it is felt that if mending the company's affairs is difficult it will be a charitable act to end it and prevent